2027 GPPN Conference – Call for Proposals

Technology and the Public Good

18-20 February 2027
LSE School of Public Policy, London

Conference Theme

The theme of the 2027 GPPN Conference is ***Technology and the Public Good.***

Rapid advances in artificial intelligence, data science, and digital technologies are transforming how we work, access public services, participate in society, and interact with government. While these technologies create new opportunities, they can also generate new policy challenges and inequalities, leaving individuals and communities behind.

We invite students to identify a specific public policy challenge created or transformed by technological change and propose a concrete, actionable policy intervention to address it. Proposals might consider how governments can harness technology to improve lives, expand access and opportunity, protect citizens from emerging harms, or ensure that the benefits of technological change are widely shared and equitable. Projects may also address developing new policy responses to the challenges technological change creates.

- Proposals should identify a specific public policy challenge and explain how the solution would deliver measurable public benefit.
- Proposals should identify a specific public policy challenge and explain how the proposed solution would improve policy outcomes.
- If teams propose a technological solution, they should clearly articulate the policy change and the societal challenge it addresses, rather than presenting technology as the end in itself.
- Successful entries will demonstrate both innovation and a clear understanding of the policy context and impact.

All proposals must clearly identify:

- **Policy actor(s):** The specific government or public agency that your proposal is directed to (local, subnational, federal governments, or international organizations such as United Nations agencies, World Health Organization, World Bank, etc).
- **Policy domain:** The specific policy area you are addressing (e.g. public health, education, climate policy, labour markets, etc).
- **Policy problem(s):** The concrete problem(s) your proposal aims to solve, how these manifest in a policy context, and a clear proposal to amend policy to address the problem.

Selection Criteria

Proposals will be assessed using the following equally weighted criteria:

a) **Problem:** Policy analysis and strength of design (i.e. if it is based on sound analytical principles) (25%)
b) **Solution:** Implementation concerns including awareness of stakeholder interests (relevance of the solution) (25%)
c) **Implementation:** Mechanisms for learning, self-correction and refinement over time (setting up the proposal over time: the proposal must include different scenarios) (25%)
d) **Presentation:** Quality of presentation (clarity, legibility, compliance with instructions) (25%)

We are looking for proposals that demonstrate:

1. Argumentation

- Precise identification and analysis of the target population, territory, or governance context
- Thorough problem analysis that precedes discussion of solutions
- Explicit consideration of stakeholder divisions, competing interests, or jurisdictional complexities

2. Analytics & Evidence

- Strong use of data, empirics, and analytical methods
- Evidence-based approach to understanding the problem and supporting your proposed solution
- Appropriate quantitative or qualitative analysis
- Clear demonstration of how evidence informs your policy design

3. Implementation Strategy

- Astute understanding of political economy and stakeholder interests
- Realistic assessment of implementation barriers
- Clear mechanisms for building coalitions or navigating opposition
- Consideration of sequencing, timing, and institutional capacity
- Attention to how your policy functions across divided contexts

4. Learning & Adaptation

- Mechanisms for monitoring, evaluation, and course correction
- Multiple scenarios or contingencies based on different levels of cooperation/resistance
- Awareness of when similar solutions have been tried previously
- Understanding of why past efforts succeeded, failed, or required modification
- Built-in flexibility to adapt to changing political or social conditions

Team Formation

Students should form teams of **2 members minimum and 3 members maximum** and work together to develop their proposals. A student cannot be a member of more than one team, and no team can submit more than one proposal.

Conference Format

Teams will each deliver a presentation of up to three minutes on Friday 19 February. Following these presentations, the Jury of Deans will select up to eight teams to progress to the final round. The selected teams will present again on Saturday 20 February. Finalists will have up to five minutes to present their proposal, followed by a short question-and-answer session with the Jury of Deans.

Please note that attendance is **mandatory throughout the conference** for all students selected to participate.

Accommodation

Hotel accommodation will be provided for all participating students, with double- and triple-occupancy rooms in a central London location booked for the nights of **18, 19 and 20 February 2027**. Prior to the conference, each participating school will be advised of its room allocation and asked to confirm room-sharing arrangements.

To apply

Please complete this form to submit your team's proposal by **23 October 2026.** Your proposal should not be longer than **1000 words (excluding diagrams and references)**. Applications are open to first- and second-year master's students in all our programmes (EMPA, MDS, MIA, MPP).

Questions? Contact Sarah Lawton-Görlach (lawton@hertie-school.org).

We will preselect up to 8 Hertie School teams for an oral selection round. After this preliminary round, we will select 3 to 4 teams to compete in the final competition in London.

Helpful tips for successful proposals

The GPPN competition is ultimately about designing a **credible, evidence-based policy solution.** The strongest proposals are rarely the most ambitious, but the ones that combine rigorous analysis with realistic implementation. GPPN evaluates proposals on four key dimensions: problem analysis, use of evidence, implementation, and benchmarking

1. **Define a specific problem**: focus on a clearly defined policy challenge; identify a specific target population, geography, or institution; quantify the problem with data before proposing solutions.
2. **Understand the stakeholders**: map who benefits, who pays, who implements, and who may resist; demonstrate awareness of political and institutional realities
3. **Prioritise policy over technology**: avoid presenting an app, platform or AI tool as the solution itself; technology should support a well-designed policy intervention, not replace it
4. **Show how the proposal will be implemented**: this should include **concrete** details, such as: Who is responsible? How is it funded? What is the timeline? What legal or regulatory changes are needed? How will success be measured?
5. **Benchmark against existing examples**: show where similar approaches have been tried before as well as what worked, what failed, and how your proposal builds on this
6. **Use data convincingly**: support claims with evidence, include figures on costs expected impact, and relevant trends
7. **Think globally, solve locally**: Connect a major global challenge to a practical and scalable local solution; demonstrate relevant beyond the single case
8. **Build a complementary team**: Successful teams have combined policy analysis, quantitative skills, subject-matter expertise, and strong presentation skills
9. **Present for a dean-level audience:** the proposals at the competition are judged by the deans of leading public policy schools
10. **Invest in the presentation:** Successful presentations have clean, visually appealing slides, been rehearsed extensively, anticipated difficult questions and ensured smooth transitions between speakers